

To book a building inspection, three reliable touch-points are Archicentre (archicentreaustralia.com.au), the Australian Society of Building Consultants (asbc.com.au) and Master Builders Australia (masterbuilders.com.au). These organisations will help you to understand the process, what it will cover, what else you might need beyond a basic inspection, and how to track down a qualified building expert in your area.

Before you proceed, as it can be a costly exercise to book an inspection – especially if you need to do this for more than one property after you get beaten at auction, time and again, as is often the way for first home buyers – be sure the inspector:

- Holds a licence
- Will provide you with a written report of their findings
- Has professional indemnity insurance, which covers mistakes and overlooked problems, and ensures that if there is something wrong with your property and they didn't alert you, you have an avenue for restitution.

A building inspector's fee can be up to \$1000, or as little as a few hundred dollars, and for this they should audit all visible aspects of the property you wish to buy, such as:

- Structures on the site, including the home, shed and garage
- The roof, steps, decks, fences, paths and the driveway
- Water drainage
- The roof cavity
- The underfloor area.

They generally will not check:

- Electrical wiring and appliances
- Plumbing
- Pools
- The home's foundations, if they are not a qualified structural engineer (this inspection needs to be arranged separately).

What a pest